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John Abercrombie

Guitarist John Abercrombie was born in Port Chester, New York on December 16, 1944. He attended the Berklee School of Music in the mid-60s and gained his first professional jazz experience with organist Johnny "Hammond" Smith. His lengthy discography includes work with an impressive list of jazz luminaries. He is capable of playing in many stylistic settings and has led his own ensembles since the mid-1970s.

John was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 19, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming at Hamilton College for the Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have John Abercrombie with me today.

JA: Nice to be here.

MR: Welcome to the college.

JA: Thanks.

MR: Looking forward to your performance tonight.

JA: Me too, yeah. It should be really nice. It's a trio tonight, which is how this band really started, we started as guitar, organ and drums, and we've added different instruments along the way but for this particular performance we're back to our sort of beginnings kind of, which is nice.

MR: Almost eight years you guys have been—

JA: Yeah it's about that, could be even a little longer. I'm not sure, again, time passes so quickly I'm not sure when the first thing was recorded but it was the first album or CD was a thing called "While We're Young" on ECM and that was recorded after we had been playing some gigs together and we were starting. And then there was the second one called "Speak of the Devil," a live record which I just listened to in the car coming up today, I sort of wanted to remind myself what we sounded like as a trio, and that's called "Tactics," which was recorded live in New York. And then there was an album called "Open Land" that came out about I guess two years ago. And that had Joe Lovano and Mark Feldman on violin and Kenny Wheeler, so it was more like a project.

MR: I'm glad you listened to that today because you anticipated one of my questions.

JA: Oh, okay.

MR: That was if you listen to a tape of tonight's performance, whatever happens, and then you listen to what you guys were doing seven or eight years ago, how does it change?

JA: I think what changes for me is just that, I mean usually we're off all doing different things and then we come back together and I find that either with this band or with other bands, just hopefully you get better. I think I find I'm able to — my phrasing is a little

different, I have a little more control over what I do than I did when that album was recorded, and if I listen to that album and go back and listen to something earlier I realize oh, boy I had much more control when we recorded the live album. So I think what happens is you just get the ability to, at least I do, to shape things as they're happening a little more. You get a little more mature. Maybe you're not quite as wild and crazy you know. But there's still that element in there too.

MR: You know that term "wild," I've been reading some of your past interviews.

JA: Oh really? Does it crop up a lot?

MR: It does. You talked about some of your playing, especially in the fusion world, and that you felt you were kind of wild and you actually said that your timing suffered for it. Do you still feel that way?

JA: I still feel, I think a certain kind of timing suffered by playing that music. I think I gained something from it too because most of that music, it was very much harmonically it had no motion, I mean it mostly, your solos were over one chord and maybe two if you really got lucky. And all the rhythms were very sort of straight ahead, almost rock rhythms. You know they were what we would refer to as even eighth note rhythms, or more Latin style, as opposed to jazz swing. So I think what suffered was my ability to play the jazz feeling, the jazz time, swing feel. Because I just hadn't been doing it. I was playing a sort of even eighth note rock & roll, and then also somewhere in-between Mahavishnu Indian thing, which is all very even oriented. So the beats were always da- da- da- da- da- da- da, kind of evenly divided, and the jazz is of course much looser. So think what happened when I came back to try and play jazz is that's when I found like gee my time is really kind of odd. You know I play kind of speedy and nervous for jazz. So I had to kind of re-think things and re-examine how I wanted to play.

MR: Okay. I want to take you back a little bit. You had some experience at Berklee?

JA: Oh sure.

MR: Would you be able to put a percentage of what you play now and attribute any of it to your quote formal education?

JA: Yeah I think so. I don't know if I'd attribute it as much to the actual education that I got from specific teachers. I think it was more just the experience of being in school playing and developing and being around teachers and other students. And if anything I would attribute certain things of course to, there were a couple of teachers that were very important to me, Herb Pomeroy was one, he was a wonderful trumpet player but his main job at Berklee was to teach — he taught arranging, he taught advanced arranging, which was sort of not really, almost in the style of Duke Ellington but that was his guy, you know so he loved Duke and he kind of like wrote in that style and more modern if you can do that, because Duke's stuff was pretty modern. And he also led the jazz workshops,

which were small ensembles of anywhere from like four to maybe six people. It could be a couple of horns for the rhythm section — I was in one that was just guitar and saxophone, piano, bass and drums. And it was wonderful because I had to function like a horn player. And I couldn't read worth — I was terrible. I mean most guitar players will acknowledge that they, it's a difficult instrument to read on. So I remember when they would first write tunes on the board and the saxophone player could read quite well. And I could read, I could kind of read notes, I knew what the pitches were, but I was terrible at reading rhythms. I just didn't know how to do it. So I'd find the notes on the guitar and I would listen to the saxophone player like mad just to find out [scats] okay. I'd kind of listen and then I'd get it a few times through. But I think I would have to attribute like a lot of things to Herb and his, not just specific things, but just his inspiration, his confidence building. He was a great — he knew how to say things to you like that was very good, or like avoid this. Constructive criticisms. I think mostly I'd have to say Herb, and then my guitar instructor who is a wonderful guy who still lives in Florida named Jack Peterson. And he was, every week he would change his mind about what you should be learning. Because he was a new teacher. The first year I went to Berklee was his first year teaching. And he was from Texas. So I'd come in and he'd say, "Remember what I showed you, Johnny" you know, "last week?" I said, "Yeah, Jack." He said, "Well forget about that now I want you to — here. Here's some Bach violin concertos and I want you to go home and learn this." I said, "Re-learn this?" So and then next week, forget Bach and then it was back to Charlie Christian or — so he was always changing. And he was such a good player that he was very inspiring. So I think I remember those two teachers the most, and then it was just the atmosphere of the school, playing all the time, and then one day you kind of just, you play something and you feel a little more connected than you did. You just sort of hear it a little better and you say oh, maybe I can play music. In the beginning it's all like a lot of self-doubt more than anything, and I think it's, gee, do I sound good? Can I play? What is this anyway? And then one day you sort of cross into another area where you begin, your ears begin to open up and you get some confidence and I think that came from school and playing with a lot of these people.

MR: What kind of music was in your household when you were growing up as a kid?

JA: I remember on the television, I remember distinctly, I remember two things, I remember Lawrence Welk was on the television and then there was a lot of country music on the television. I remember at the time there was these sort of country shows and there was like a young girl, I think a brother and sister that played like guitars and mandolins and they used to play double neck things, like mandolin on one and then six string on the other. And they were like, three feet high, I mean these were kids. And they were playing faster than the speed of light. They were playing all these country rags. But this wasn't

music that my parents listened to, we didn't really have music in the house in terms of there was no, there was a victrola I guess, not a wind-up kind I mean you actually plugged it in and it went around, you didn't have to crank it up, you know, I'm not quite that old. So they bought me a record player. I think the music came from outside the house. Because the only music in the house really was Lawrence and this country stuff. And I knew pretty early on that Lawrence wasn't for me. I don't know, something just didn't click. I didn't get it. I later learned to like champagne a little bit, you know, from the champagne ladies, and all the bubbles, but I didn't really—

MR: What about the rock & roll of the day, the Ventures and all that kind of thing?

JA: That was influential for sure, yeah. I mean I think because I had chosen the guitar as an instrument, and I didn't choose it because of Charlie Christian or Barney Kessel or Wes Montgomery, I chose it because of people like you're mentioning, you know like Chuck Berry, the Ventures, Bo Diddley, Elvis Presley and all these kind of people. So I chose it as a way to like maybe gain social acceptance you know. And plus I liked the sound of the electric guitar. And my first guitar was acoustic. It was a Harmony guitar. I mean I think it was $40 and you could barely put the strings onto the fretboard. I used it once as a baseball bat I remember. I took it outside and I said to somebody, "Throw me one," and you know, and I cracked the guitar. I always remember that.

MR: Oh, this is a true story.

JA: It is a true story, really, yeah. Well I liked baseball too. Maybe I just got confused in my playing. Do I want to play baseball or guitar? Well let's use the guitar as a baseball bat. And we can sort of do two things. But once I got an electric guitar I think I was kind of like bitten by the sound. There was something about this sound coming from the speaker, more than an acoustic instrument. It was just something really exciting and very electric about it, it was an electric guitar. It was very cool. And I loved Chuck Berry. And there was actually a singing duo at the time that I remember very distinctly called Mickey and Sylvia.

MR: Yeah. "Love is Strange."

JA: "Love is Strange" was a song that was very popular when I was growing up and you could hear it on the jukebox, which is where I heard a lot of the music. You know you'd drop the nickel into the slot you know and press the button and there it would come. And one of these things was "Love is Strange." And they had these really hip sounding electric guitars with maybe tremolo or some kind of weird little effect on them you know at the time. And it just — and then I saw pictures of them and they were playing like sort of solid body Les Paul guitars and I saw this is so cool, I mean I have to know what this is about. So yeah, that music was very important to me. I still like it. But that took me just quickly into hearing electric guitar. And I remember we were talking earlier, I heard

Tony Mottola play on the "Perry Como Show." And he was playing a Gibson electric guitar and he would sit on a little stool and play pretty chords. And so I got a guitar teacher and I asked my guitar teacher, I said, "Can you show me what these pretty chords are that Tony Mottola plays?" And he could. He was a good guitar teacher. So that kind of got me into wanting to play something else. And then I think the first jazz guitar I really heard was Barney Kessel. And that sold me on the idea that I wanted to play jazz on the guitar and not rock & roll.

MR: And at what age was that kind of decision?

JA: Early. The beginning of high school years, probably like 13, 14. And you know early teenager. And I had some friends in my town who were two brothers who played music and they would take me into their little room where they had their stash of records and they'd play me Dave Brubeck, Miles, Barney Kessel, Horace Silver, whatever. And so they were really hip and way ahead of the time. Of course then I went to my mother and told her I wanted to be a jazz musician. You have to realize I'm first generation, my parents come from England and Scotland, so I mean it would have been difficult for American parents to understand jazz or even know what it meant but for them it was like, jazz? What's jazz? Nobody knows what jazz is. And even in my high school most people didn't know what jazz was, and I remember the music teacher trying to discourage me from wanting to go to music school to study jazz. She says, "You don't really want to do that, John, do something serious." I said well, "But we like the way this sounds." So in other words in the 50s you couldn't get a lot of encouragement if you were a young, White kid in the suburbs, because the music wasn't there. Nobody listened to it. And so you kind of had to like say well this is what I really want. And then I found Berklee, which was really probably one of the greatest things because Berklee was one of the only places that taught jazz and was serious about it. There were very, very few places that would even accept a guitar, even if you played classical guitar you couldn't get in, there was no program for it. Of course here I was with my little Gretch electric guitar and my amplifier and I wanted to play music. And I opened up the Berklee catalogue and there was a picture of Gabor Szabo from Hungary, standing there with a Gretch guitar. I said I relate. I can go here, you know, this guy plays electric guitar and he's studying at this school. And I went there and I think there were like ten guitar players the first year. Now there's about over a thousand. Unbelievable how much it's grown. But that was kind of how I got into playing guitar. So the 50s rock & roll was very important to me. And then I kind of naturally seemed to move into Barney Kessel, who like I say was the first one, and I still love the way he plays. But he was the first one I really heard that excited me and made me want to play the guitar.

MR: Did you go the garage band route at all?

JA: Yeah, we had bands like that, sure. I was in a couple of bands like that. The first band I was in I think was, the very first band I played in had accordion, guitar, drums, maracas, and harmonica and trumpet. It was interesting. I mean it probably would be a hip band today. You could probably get on a lot of European festivals playing with this kind of oddball band, call it world music now or something, you know, Mariachi, some polka, I don't know, electric guitar. I think you could make a concept out of it. But basically we played VFW halls and polka gigs. And the accordion player's father was Polish and got us all these Polish American clubs. And then I was in a second band that played, it had three guitars, now no bass, no bass guitar, this was three guitars, three electric guitars. And the way it was broken up it was like the Ventures, it was one of those bands, where one guy would play sort of the lead part, the higher part. The other guy would strum chords, and then there was a third part, it was the in-between part, it was sort of like you play honky-tonk like ding- ding- ding- ding- ding, sort of like muted guitar kind of, you play in fifths. So there was actually these three parts. It was really orchestrated. And that's the way the guitar bands played. And that was really a garage band. And we would just sit down and work it out, all by ear, none of us could read, just took things from records. One guy would do this, one guy would do that, and I was just starting to learn how to play pretty chords, you know, from my other teacher. So I would bring in some of that. And then we got a saxophone player who could play a couple of standards so then we would start adding things like "Tenderly" or "Misty" or something to the — "Harlem Nocturne," these kind of tunes. So you could see it's starting, there was a move towards jazz but there was still this garage band guitar mentality.

MR: Well that stuff is expanding your harmonic knowledge for sure, to get into "Harlem Nocturne" and those kinds of things.

JA: Yeah. Immediately. And there was something about it, it was so enticing just kind of all of a sudden hearing some of these minor major seventh chords, this harmony which doesn't exist in rock & roll.

MR: I always find it interesting, the communication element. Because I remember playing with my first rock & roll guitarist who had been playing for a long time, and he played an interesting chord and I said what's that? And he'd say "this," you know he'd hold up his hand. And I go well that doesn't mean anything to me. Do guitar players like, with that trio of guitar players, is that how you would communicate some?

JA: Yeah, sometimes. Sometimes we would do that. I didn't really know the names of everything I was playing. Yeah I would just kind of give them one of these you know, and then other guys would go wow, look at that, I mean he can stretch more than one fret, how can he do that? And then later I started to learn what the names of them were so if somebody would say what's that, I'd say that's a G thirteenth, man. And then when I

went to Berklee then I said it's a G seventh with an added thirteenth. You know, then I got even hipper. But in the beginning you don't know what it is, because I leaned it all by rote. You know my teacher would show me a chord melody, that is where you play the chords and the melody kind of together. And the first thing I learned I think was "Misty" or "Tenderly," it was one of the two I forget.

MR: It was "Misty."

JA: It was.

MR: I read that.

JA: Okay, it was "Misty" you're right. So you've got like laa-chord-note-chord, with the melody on top. And then chord-chord-chord, da-da. It was kind of corny but it made you, it opened up my ears to this kind of harmony. But I didn't know what I was playing. I just did it by rote. And then later I learned that this was the one chord and this was the four chord, and this was like a subdominant minor. But I mean that's when I went to school. And then I started to put together, then I started to hear it. And then once you hear it you don't really even have to know what it is anymore because that's what it is, it's what you hear. You know, in deep, so you don't need to know the name of it anymore and that became really apparent when you listen to guys play like Wes Montgomery and Wes couldn't tell you what chords he was playing. Because he came to the school once, he was invited to the school, this was really an early kind of like workshop. They invited him to the school to play for the kids. And he came to Berklee, we all met him, and the instructor at the time, Jack Peterson, had this little guitar ensemble, which was like seven or eight guitarists playing arrangements, right? And so we were going to play this arrangement and let Wes solo on it. So Jack gave him the music. He went to put it on Wes' stand. And Wes went, "No, no, no, I don't—" And we sort of all knew, you know, that he didn't read music. So he says, "Just play it for me." So we played the tune once, I mean played through the arrangement, and then it came time for the solo section and Wes just soloed. I mean he heard it, he heard exactly where the chord progression went, and it wasn't that — it moved through a couple of keys, you know, key changes, not tempo changes. And he just nailed it. Because he could hear it. And that was like a real lesson right there. Well gee, I don't have to know what all these scales and chords are. It doesn't hurt that I do, but here's a guy that just hears it. Probably can't even tell you what key he's in. It's unbelievable. And Chet Baker apparently was the same way. He was a very natural player. But when you do arrive to a point where you hear it, that's what it is and you don't really have to codify it so much unless you're trying to teach it. And today as a teacher I mean I have to be able to like keep up with students. And they'll start to run circles around me when they're talking about the theory you know.

MR: And the modes and that kind of thing.

JA: And all that kind of stuff, I go okay, slow down, now wait a minute, this is a melodic minor. Tell me what this again. I have to ask the student and they'll say it's this. And I'll say well yeah I know that but I wasn't sure that's what it was called. Sometimes you forget the names, which is the ultimate goal, which is to forget all that and just — and that's what Herb Pomeroy said to me years ago, which is why I liked him so much. I said, "Herb, why do I have to learn all these chords and scales? Why can't I just play?" He said, with a Boston accent, "John, just learn all this stuff and then forget it, and then you can get on with playing music." And that always made so much sense to me. Just learn it and then forget it, or don't think about it. It's in there, you don't have to think about it.

MR: Okay. You don't have to know what it's called—

JA: No.

MR: —it's available to you through your ears.

JA: Through your ears, and also you've studied it and you know what it is so if you had to recall it and tell someone like what the name of it is, to give it a name, you could do it but that's not what's the most important. The most important is what's in your head and how you can do it.

MR: Okay. It got to a point at Berklee where, did you feel like I'm ready to get out and play? Well let me rephrase that. Did you get out and play, like with Johnny Hammond, before you felt you were ready?

JA: I think I was — I was nervous about it and I was still in school when I was playing with Johnny Hammond. I mean I might have been in my third year, I mean, and I got recommended to Johnny Hammond through — I used to play in a rhythm & blues band called the Danny Wright Orchestra. And Danny Wright's band had an interesting rhythm section. It actually had a drummer that became my drummer years later, Peter Donald, who lives in California, a wonderful pianist named Carl Schroeder, who is a mad scientist who teaches out in California at one of the music institutes. But it was like three or four horns and a rhythm section. And I started to play a lot in this band, also Mark Levine, the trombone player who you may be familiar with, he plays trombone and piano, and got a lot of help playing in that band, I learned a lot and then Danny thought I was, the leader though well you could play with this guy Johnny Hammond, he's looking for a guitar player, I'll recommend you. I said, "Really, you think, I mean, you think I could do this?" He said, "Well you know a lot of standards, right?" I said I knew a fair amount. And that was it. He just called up Johnny and Johnny said well bring your guitar down to this club, and it was a club in Boston which is no longer in existence. But it was near a club that still functions as a club now called Wally's that a lot of the students go to. And Wally's was there when I was a kid but this other club was called the Big M, which stood for Morley's on the Avenue. I never met Mr. Morley, I don't think I ever wanted to meet Mr.

Morley, you know. It wasn't important. But that's where we played seven nights a week and a matinee on Sunday. And you'd play like three or four sets a night. You know you'd play 'till like two in the morning, and you'd get up and go to school. And it was at that point where I realized I really wanted to be a player. I was out playing professionally then, and playing with people that had nothing to do with the school, a guy that wouldn't know one mode from the other, could care less how much you knew. All he just really wanted to know, did you know the song? Could you swing? Could you play the right changes? Could you play four-four rhythm like Freddie Green? He said "play four-four, man, I just want to hear four-four." Or Charleston. Really simple, but then once he got to know you you could play almost anything. It was a real great place to learn to become more of a traditional musician and also, a thing that doesn't exist anymore, these kind of apprenticeships in places, especially for a guitarist, especially now that all the organ players are dying. I mean Jack McDuff's gone, Groove Holmes is gone, Johnny's gone. And those were the places where young guitar players got a lot of that experience. And it doesn't happen anymore. So I was lucky that I got in when I did and, yeah, it was at that point that I kind of knew I wanted to play. I still wasn't totally secure in what was going on but I knew I wanted to play that kind of music. And then everything changed, then it became the late 60s and I met Michael and Randy Brecker and they recommended me for a band called Dreams, which was a fusion band with a singer. So I went to New York and started playing.

MR: Can you recall what kind of money you were making, in that six nights a week thing?

JA: Well I do know that after I played with him for like a year it was, I think the deal was it was $90 a week in town, I remember him telling that once, and then $110 on the road, pay your own hotel.

MR: Let me do the math there.

JA: Yeah. Well everything was so much cheaper in those days, and we used to stay at hotels that were pretty much near the clubs, a lot of them were in ghettos so they weren't so expensive. And it didn't really cost that much money to be on the road in those days. But I remember him telling me that, $90 a week in town, $110 on the road, pay your own hotel. So if I worked with him, when I moved to New York, that was when I moved to New York. I don't know what he paid me in Boston, it was probably less, because I was just a student. And then I went kind of on the road with him and we played — I moved to New York and I used to live in a hotel. In those days you could get a hotel by the week and it would be like twenty-some bucks a week, with maid service. So I'd live in these hotels and we'd play a lot of times at Count Basie's Lounge, or these clubs in Harlem. It was Count Basie's, there was a club called Wells, it was near Small's Paradise, which I never played at, but there was about three or four of them, Club Baron, which I did play

at. There was a place in New Jersey called the Key Club that I played at. And so you'd start to play all these joints and then, that's when he started paying me a little more money. And I began to become more of a professional musician. I also was out of Boston and now I was in New York. And I didn't stay there, I went back to Boston, and it took me a couple of times to actually land in New York. Even when I met Mike and Randy I was still torn between Boston and New York. But I went on the road with this band called Dreams. Now I was in a completely different thing. With Johnny I wore a suit and tie and I played "If I Were a Bell" and blues, and all these kind of tunes. And when I started playing with the Dreams band I wore leather pants and headbands and I played with wah-wah pedals and played over one chord. I mean I got a real identity crisis. I didn't know where I was going. Because I had really wanted to be just a jazz player and then all this explosion happened and then, whatever Miles Davis did, everybody did. If Miles got a wah-wah pedal, everybody played with a wah-wah pedal. Trumpet players, saxophone players, it didn't matter. Of course guitar players always had the wah-wah pedal.

MR: Were Blood Sweat & Tears and Chicago a reason for some of those things?

JA: I think they were a definite reason for Dreams. I think Dreams was a band that was, I mean the guys liked to play that way, but the band was also put together to try to be successful. I mean they saw the success of Blood, Sweat & Tears and Randy Brecker had been in Blood Sweat & Tears and actually left before the band went gold. I mean he did an album with them called "The Child Is Father To The Man," and then he quit, he said I don't want to do this stuff, and then Lew Soloff took the gig and Lew was on the famous "Spinning Wheel" record and that went, wherever it went, and Randy could have kicked himself I think. So Dreams was kind of started to try to be a band like that, but it just wasn't as successful because it was too weird. The horn players were too interesting. The guitar player was completely off the wall, me. The singer was, he was a pretty good singer but he wasn't powerful like David Clayton Thomas or one of those guys, so the band never really, it didn't quite know what it wanted to do. And so that band kind of, I left that band and went back to Boston to play in another band with electric vibes and drums, and it was called The Stark Reality, which I've never spoken of much in interviews but it was led by a vibes player named Monty Stark, therefore the name The Stark Reality. And Monty had fuzz and everything on his vibes. He was a very creative, interesting guy, still is to the best of my knowledge, and so I'm back and played with them for a couple of years. We made one CD, which was the music of Hoagy Carmichael's, it was Hoagy Carmichael's childrens' music. This is very odd because Hoagy Carmichael's son, Hoagy Junior, worked at a television station in Boston, WGBH, we all became friends because Monty was doing some music for the television thing, so Hoagy kind of hooked us up with his father. His father had this book of kid's tunes. It's

the strangest thing in the world. And we recorded them for Ahmad Jamal's record label, which I think was called AJP Records, which I think had our record on it and maybe one other record and then went bankrupt. My mother is the only person with a copy of this record. It was just hysterical things that I was involved in. And then finally in the early 70s I moved to New York to play with Chico Hamilton on a recommendation from a friend who was leaving the band. And that's when I moved to stay. And then I never went back to Boston. And then I started becoming a New York musician.

MR: Did your parents become comfortable with your choice of living eventually?

JA: Eventually they did but it took a long time I think. I don't know if it ever really quite sunk in, you know, because they'd always say well why don't you — can't you go back — because I didn't quite finish Berklee. I didn't get the degree, the music ed degree. And they said, "Can't you go back to Berklee and finish and get that?" And I said no, no, I'm working now. And it sort of reminds me of like, there was one Woody Allen movie where his parents come on at the very end, I forget which one it is, and they are saying, "Ve don know, I mean he could have been a lawyer, he could have done that, look vhat he did vis his life." You know, and then we're talking about someone who's ridiculously successful doing exactly what he wants to do, but I think parents never let go of that somehow. But luckily, what I always appreciated was that even though they had no idea what I wanted to do, they let me at least pursue it. And when they saw I was making a living they just said fine. I think in their own way they were proud of what I did but they never really understood the music. But that's okay. I'm not sure I do sometimes.

MR: You seem to have had your tastes in a lot of different places. Has it always been of your own choosing?

JA: No. I mean I think it gets mixed up. Sometimes it's hard to know whether or not it's your own choosing. Sometimes you find yourself in a situation that you think you wanted to get in and then once you're in it you realize you shouldn't be there. I'd say since I started playing this music, most of it's been pretty much stuff I like to do. It hasn't always been my own choosing. Sometimes somebody will hire me and I need the gig. Especially when I was younger and I would take any gig that was offered to me from the time I started working in Boston and as a musician until I moved to New York, where do I go, how much do I make, what do I have to play. And then as I got a little older and I sort of found myself getting a little bit of a reputation I found that I could do more of what I wanted to do, not that I could do everything I wanted to do for sure, I still can't, but more or less, especially once I started recording for ECM and starting to develop more of an identity, you know, and I had my own records. And that happened pretty quickly in the early 70s, around '74. And before that I had worked with Billy Cobham, which was a great experience. And that was like a return to the Dreams band because it also had

Michael and Randy. And then I got a phone call one morning from Jack DeJohnette and he just asked me if I wanted to come up and play at his house. And I said sure. So I went up and we played and we started a relationship, and that would sort of pull me back away from the pure fusion music and put me back closer to where I had started.

MR: That's really interesting how names get passed around and people just call you because—

JA: It's all word of mouth. Yeah. He didn't know what I played like, but he knew someone had mentioned my name to someone and they mentioned it to Jack and he was looking to start a band and try to do something. He wasn't playing with Miles anymore. He was kind of on his own. And as a matter of fact one time we had a band with myself and Mick Goodrick, also a great guitar player, and Ron McClure. And then we had a band with Clint Houston, a bass player, and then finally Jack formed a band with myself and Alex Foster, a saxophone player, and Mike Richmond on bass. And we toured for a while as a band and made a couple of records for Manfred — Manfred, I say Manfred — ECM. Manfred Eicher. But that's when I met Manfred and ECM and I met Ralph Towner and then this whole thing started with ECM and I did my first recording in '74. And I knew Jack so I asked him to be on it, and I had known Jan Hammer, the great Czech musician, because we used to share an apartment in Boston, me, him and George Mraz. It was like two Czechs and whatever I was, maybe I was a bounced check, I don't know. But we shared an apartment together so I knew them just as friends and roommates. And Jan was just such a tremendous musician, and I knew he played organ and see I wanted to do something that reminded me of where I had come from so that's why I chose him because he could play such great organ. And we did this record in '74 which sounds nothing like an organ trio record for the most part, but it's there. The sound of the organ is there but the music is very different.

MR: Yeah. I love — the critics sometimes let their personal feelings show. This one fellow said, from the *CD Guide to Jazz*, he says, "John is cited, or blamed, for helping create the ECM sound."

JA: Cited or blamed.

MR: Apparently he didn't like the ECM sound too much.

JA: He didn't like ECM. Well it's too bad for him. I mean also I don't think, I mean in a way ECM, you know I mean people talk about that, it's just, I mean ECM was a recording label before I went on it, I mean they were recording Jan Garbarek, they had recorded Keith Jarrett, they had recorded Ralph Towner, Eberhard Weber, European musicians. So it was starting to develop, it was just the beginning. The first records I think Paul Bley had a record, you know, and all of a sudden Manfred decided he'd like to record me. So I think my first record, so that's when I started recording in '74, I think the label actually started probably maybe in the very late 60s, like '69 or '68, '69 or maybe not 'till '70.

And I think after a while I think a lot of the recordings were done in particular studios, like you know Oslo or in Stuttgart, a lot of times they were done with similar musicians playing with each other, like I might be playing on a record with Kenny Wheeler and then there was Jack DeJohnette and then there'd be a Jack DeJohnette record that I would play on and then Jack would play with or Kenny would play with somebody else and Jan Garbarek would play and then I did a record with Jan Garbarek. And you know did a record with Enrico Rava which had a Norwegian rhythm section. You wind up playing with a lot of players who play with these other people and you do them in the same studios, the engineer most of the time was this wonderful guy Jan Eric Kongshaug who is a Norwegian and a great engineer and also a great guitar player. And Manfred Eicher was always the producer. So you take a lot of similar musicians, the same producer, a lot of times the same studios, one or two of the same engineers, you're going to wind up with something that doesn't, there's a consistency to the sound and if you go back and listen to Blue Note records they all sound — Joe Henderson is playing with McCoy and then McCoy asked Joe Henderson to play on his records. I mean maybe it's stylistically, what that guy was talking about is he just doesn't like the way things were recorded. I always thought ECM records were some of the, especially in the present day, were some of the more better and beautifully recorded recordings. I think I also love Blue Note records and Columbia records, but you know, I never was too crazy about CTI, which had a sound too, which sort of sounded a little plasticy to me, slick. And I think ECM just had a wonderful way of sort of like making the music sound like it's very, not coming from like there's the guitar, there's the piano, there's the drums. It made it sound like we were all playing in the same place and had some kind of a group sound to it.

MR: Do you think European musicians play significantly different?

JA: Some of them do, for sure. I think you take someone like Jan Garbarek and he can play the saxophone in a lot of different ways. But you're going to hear a very strong Norwegian, folk kind of element in his playing because that's what he wants to pursue. But there are also a lot of European musicians who pride themselves on playing bebop and that want to be like American jazz musicians, and there you won't hear much difference really. I mean you'll hear guys pretty much sound, it's interesting, they sound the same like in Stuttgart or Tokyo or Gunzburg or anyplace you go, if they study the same music, if they're all playing out of *The Real Book*, and they're all playing "Stella By Starlight," and they all listen to Lee Morgan records, they're all going to wind up sounding the same. You could say that's a sound. I mean why was he cited or blamed for playing the trumpet that way you know. Everyone imitated him and he made a sound. Charlie Parker could be blamed for a lot of, you know, everyone trying to sound like Charlie Parker.

MR: Right.

JA: But then when you find musicians, I think especially more and more now you find European musicians who go back to their roots, go back to the music of their country, they try to incorporate the music of Norway or Sweden or wherever they happen to be coming from, I mean, into jazz. And then you have other people that record for ECM that I mean there's this wonderful oud player named Anouar Brahem, I'm not sure if I'm pronouncing it right, but he doesn't play jazz at all, he plays oud. But he improvises you know. And he did an album with Dave Holland, it's wonderful. But then again you start to raise the other question, well what is jazz. Yeah I mean a lot of what's on ECM I wouldn't consider coming from a pure strain of jazz at all but it's coming from the spirit of it which has to do with a lot of improvising. And that's one of the aspects of jazz that can take it away from being the pure form of jazz which has to do with blues and African-American music and what the Ken Burns show presented, which is definitely true, and I really believe in that. There's a pure strain of jazz. But then there's something else. There's jazz influence and inspired and that's improvisation and I think maybe you don't quite call it jazz in the pure sense, but it's jazz in the spirit of what the music is and I think there's a lot of disservice when they don't talk about that kind of music because there's some great improvisers who don't play in the jazz tradition you know. I happen to be kind of caught in the whole, I'm walking funny lines because I mean I really consider I'm a jazz guitar player but I also like to play things that sound nothing like jazz. And it doesn't bother me at all you know. I don't feel like I'm breaking the rules you know.

MR: How much has the changing technology allowed you or helped you to do some of that, to go in those different directions?

JA: At one time I thought maybe it had a lot to do with it but I really don't think it has too much to do with it. I think I've always enjoyed, even in a low tech world, to experiment and try to pull things out of the guitar that made it sound not so much like a guitar. I think the only period where it became even further removed from that was when things got more synthetic. I was fooling around with a guitar synthesizer when the guitar was attached to all sorts of keyboards and modules and then it really started to, I enjoyed it, but it started to get so far away from playing the guitar that, and I — and there was also a lot of problems involved and a lot of equipment, and just too much stuff, you can't go on the road, you can't travel with all this, so I just basically gave it all away and went back to playing the guitar. So I really think maybe that was one place where technology kind of came in and said oh, you have a lot more opportunities now. You don't even have to sound like a guitar, you can sound like a flute or a piano. And that was, I went crazy with it. I thought it was just fantastic. But then after a while I just came back to the guitar. Because there was more nuance in it somehow. And there's more control. You can do

more with the string, you know you can bend it and inflect it, but you can't do that with a synthesizer as well. So I don't think the technology has played that much of a role. I think things sound better now. In the old days you didn't have much of a choice, you had like two different kinds of amplifiers to play through. Now you've got like a lot of different things you can choose from and digital reverberations and kind of things that make the music sound like it's been recorded. So when you hear it live it has a more pleasant sound to my ears then just something that's coming out of a broken, you know, Fender amp speaker. And in the old days, that's pretty much all you had. You had like an amp and you were lucky if it was working.

MR: You had stated way back in '76 that you liked Chinese and Japanese music, there's so much space in it.

JA: Yeah, oh yeah, very much. I love it. I don't listen to it so much now but I remember there was one time when I went to Japan, I went to, I don't know if you're familiar with the Noh Theater, where they wear the masks, and I think all the parts are played by men even if it's a woman, but they've got all these weird masks. And off to the side would be three guys. One was a singer, one played a string and one played a wood block or percussion. And the music was so far out. I mean it made John Cage sound like cocktail music. I mean it was like, you've got to realize this stuff is from like centuries old, and all you'd hear was this like [scats]. And I'm saying how do they count this? I mean no one's going one, two, you know. They don't have a conductor going like this. So I mean how do they feel the space? But it always sounded like they, maybe it's just the certain, maybe when I go [scats] and then you're going to go — but you have to wait, and they just know when to do it. It was amazing. It was beautiful. So I've always liked this music for that reason too, the space. I always liked the sound of it too, just the way, like I remember hearing a Chinese violin being played somewhere at a ferry boat stopping somewhere in Seattle, there was some oriental guy and he was just sitting on the floor playing a thing with a bow. And it was just like, I mean it just opened your floodgates if you let it. I mean the sound was just so emotional and it was just this thing being bowed. I don't know, maybe a couple of strings you know. You probably would, if you heard it, it sounds like a violin but more, I don't know what they call it.

MR: I think they call it an erhu or something like that.

JA: Yeah, maybe it was that. It was absolutely just devastating, it was an amazing sound. So I always liked that kind of stuff. So I've always been, the fact if you're attracted to that then you try to draw things out of the instrument to make it sound, you try to kind of, actually you try to copy something else. You are influenced by another culture. And that's the thing I like about that music, is why I enjoy trying to play with people sometimes that I know I can't play their music but I might take some element of that and

just play with it. And then it starts to color the other music. And on top of it I still like to play swing music and bebop too, so it's a funny combination. Sometimes I don't know quite which way to go.

MR: But you're bound to satisfy yourself one way or the other.

JA: Yeah. I try to make myself feel good about what I'm playing. To the band tonight, it would be interesting to see which directions we take. We'll probably play some a little more traditional things than we would normally do with the violin with Feldman, because the band has really been going in a more outer direction with Mark in it, playing a lot of very abstract kind of pieces. With the trio we might come a little more inside. It'll be interesting to see what we do.

MR: I've always been fascinated by the challenge of hearing I guess what you would call alternate chord changes. If your organist decides to start some new substitutions that you haven't heard before, how do you nail those? Or do you?

JA: Well some of them you just hear. I mean some of them might be more things you would expect, I mean just kind of substitutions that occur a lot. He generally, he won't go too far away from what we play. I mean he won't play things that I'll never hear, unless we're improvising really freely and then you don't try to nail anything, and then the whole idea is not to really nail anything but just to sort of kind of play, it's like playing alone together. You can be playing together but you might have your own separate little story you're telling, yet you're listening to the other person and you just try to cross paths at a certain time. If somebody plays certain kinds of substitutions in a song form or a traditional song it could be, it could throw you. It depends what they play. I actually remember doing a record date once and Mark Copeland was playing piano and Peacock was, it was Mark's record, and Peacock was playing bass and we were playing a blues. And we are recording it. And I mean I had to stop because they were, it's not that they were really playing substitutions, they were just chromatically sort of moving, shifting the harmony around in such a way that I couldn't get a center on anything. And I don't know if I stopped the take or maybe I waited until it was finished and I said I mean this is great, but I have no idea what to play over it. I mean could you be a little more just traditional for me? Or maybe just, I sort of blame myself, they said, "Oh yeah, no problem." So there's sometimes you're never going get it sometimes. And I don't worry about it and if I really can I might just ask somebody, I might just say would you, what the heck were you playing, I mean what was that? Because if you play it again I want to know what it is because I didn't catch that. If I'm in doubt sometimes I just won't play. I mean I'll like let something go by.

MR: Just recently, no I'm sorry, this is 1986, you said, "Playing what you hear is the greatest challenge."

JA: I still believe it. I mean because it's very easy to get, I mean and I still do, we all do, it's very easy for us to get wrapped up in like finger wiggling or knowing you know well like or just sort of going on automatic pilot. And you have to have a certain amount of that, that's just like technique and vocabulary but it's nice to be able to really, it's nice when you can start to hear all of these things when you play that it comes out in a way that's not so premeditated and natural. And that you hear it as you're playing, you can sort of hear one phrase moving into another phrase and there's a logic to it. I still think it's the greatest challenge because I don't do it all the time. I mean I try, you know, when I'm playing at my best I'm really hearing everything for most of what I play. But it's not always going to be the case.

MR: What's the challenge of dealing with record labels and keeping your place in the market these days?

JA: I'm fortunate this way. I mean I really am because I don't have to deal with them in the same way that other people do. Some people have to change their labels every couple of years. Because if you don't sell a certain amount of records I mean it's syonara, arrivederci, hasta la vista, goodbye, so long, been nice to know you, forget about it. They just won't hire you again. With ECM I mean I can do a record every year and a half. It's not going to change, unless, I think, unless Manfred one day wakes up and says he just doesn't want to have a record company anymore and decides to sell it. Then my situation could change. So I don't really have to go to a lot of record companies and I feel very fortunate. I mean I don't have to keep shopping new stuff or call up and try and find a new label. And when I do record for another label it's always as a sideman or maybe it's a cooperative project with somebody. So I don't really worry about that because I'm not tied to that record company. So I really don't have a problem. I think it's, I think it's hard, depending if you're not with a record company that has any clout it's hard to get noticed. And you'll notice who the record companies are that really have the big machinery and the ones with the biggest machinery, the ones with the most toys at the end will win, but the ones with the biggest machinery can make the most noise, buy the most ad space, put their acts on a festival, and that, I don't like that aspect of it. Because ECM doesn't really, it's very well respected but it doesn't have that kind of clout. It doesn't really want to be that kind of a label. They're not into that. And they don't have that kind of money anyway. So the bigger American companies are the ones that, the machines. And a lot of good musicians record for them. It's just like if you get in on one of those things your chances of work and exposure are greater, but if you don't sell you're gone right away.

MR: Is there any kind of discrimination with the age of musicians these days that are landing on those kind of labels do you think?

JA: I think there probably is. I think, I would almost bet that yeah. Like if I wanted to go to another label right now at my age, I might be able to land a deal with somebody, somebody might give me a shot, because I've got a proven track record. But an older musician trying to, who isn't as established, probably wouldn't get a deal. No I think there's a tendency towards the brand new and terrific you know, or brand new. Who says whether it's terrific or not. I mean there's lots of young, brand new talent. I mean they come, you've probably heard these kind of phrases before, I mean they've seen like guys walk out of universities with their saxophone here and the press agent who's here, the manager's here, the record label's there and the suits are cut and tailored and everyone's, whoom, you know. It's a manufactured thing. And it's not that some of these guys can't play, but some of them really don't play that well. Or they're marketed very quickly. And it's interesting because I mean years ago I remember having conversations with people and saying gee, why couldn't they, or I remember conversations, gee why couldn't they sell jazz? Because in those days, I mean the only reason I knew Coltrane was playing in town was I would walk down Boylston Street in Boston and I'd see it on the marquee. John Coltrane Quartet. Hey, man, Coltrane's in town. Let's go. Bill Evans is here. Wow, cool, let's go. And the place might be packed but there might be fifteen people. There was no big hullabaloo. There was no big huge band. I mean nowadays it's like, I mean if you read some of these magazines you know and these ads for records it's like the same kind of stuff they do for movies. You know? You know when you open, if a movie is just coming out and you see the ad for the movie, "I laughed, I cried, Movie of the Year, Boston Globe nominated, I threw up watching it it was so good." And the record business is starting to look like that. You open these magazines and it's all shiny and flashy and it's a marketable thing now. It's a marketplace. Jazz, they sell it like they sell shoes.

MR: Is that good or bad?

JA: Very good question. I mean I think ultimately somehow it cheapens the whole thing. Maybe I'm just jealous though because I don't get sold that way as much. But I think it's, I'm just trying to be honest, but I think basically it's kind of, it cheapens, and it's not that it just cheapens, it sort of like tells people what they're supposed to like, people don't have the ability to make up their own minds as much as I think maybe they did some years ago. It's just all like, you know, it's what's trendy. Like cell phones are in and a certain kind of jazz is in and everything is just in and I don't know who runs this stuff. But I'd sure like to meet them and tell them what I think of them you know, because it just seems like, somebody, there's some people somewhere that do this. They sit around and they go wouldn't it be cool if we could do this and we could do that, and we could make the cell phone speak to the computer and then the jazz musician can have the cell phone implanted in his horn, and I mean I just have these weird fantasies that there's

people back there and it's a small group of people and they do this stuff and they wield a lot of influence. And I may not be that far wrong. I know I'm getting into dangerous areas but that's okay. This is for the archive and this isn't going out on public television, and if it was I would actually like it to. I wish I could do it for public, you know like—

MR: We'll see what we can arrange.

JA: Maybe you can arrange something.

MR: Maybe we can. You know if you had the opportunity to address those thousand plus guitar students at Berklee, and maybe this would be a subject you might address, but what would you say to them about how to prepare for the future of where this music is at?

JA: Oh man, I mean you could just tell them don't quit your day job, you could say, I mean the hardest thing is with a lot of players, and what I always tell the ones, I mean and I can't address a thousand of them at a time, but even with the students I have you know, if they play really good I just tell them look, I said, you know, I hope you really like this music, because if you don't I mean there's a lot of you guys around right now. I mean there's a lot of good young players. I have a couple of students at the New England Conservatory where I teach now about eight times a year. I mean they can really play. I mean I've had a few that you kind of go wow, this guy can play. Really play. And when he gets out in the real world and he's more of a — he's really going to be able to play. But where are all these guys going to work? And I always try to tell them, I always try to say look, keep yourself open to all the aspects of music, whether it's being a jazz player or maybe it's writing songs, maybe it's as a producer. I mean there could be a place in music for a lot of people but there's only so many places that people who are going to be quote unquote performers, especially jazz performers, are going to be able to play. I mean the amount of venues haven't changed dramatically since when I was starting to play and there's like a hundred times more players out there. I'm lucky I have a record label and a reputation. To be a young musician coming now, it has to be tough from that point of view, because there's so many guys and there's just not enough places to play. So I just tell them make sure you really love this stuff because you're going to have to be doing it for that reason if you want to be a jazz player because there's not going to be, and don't even worry about anything else. Just only do it for that. As long as you can get by and then if you're really true to what you do things will come your way probably, you'll make, you know, you'll make a living and you'll be able to play your music and hopefully maybe you'll get very successful.

MR: Let me run a few names by you and maybe they have an impression and maybe they don't. Eddie Lang?

JA: I don't know his playing that well but I remember kind of like the father of modern kind of guitar. One of the fathers of modern guitar for sure but I remember his playing to be

very, I don't know if virtuosic is the right word but he was more of a kind of almost like a soloist, like a real complete kind of guitarist. Could play chord melodies and kind of like a piano. He was more like a piano player when he played alone. I know that with the duets with Lonnie Johnson it was really interesting because you could hear these two really very different styles. Eddie sounded very, very calculated and in a way, very clean. And then of course Lonnie was more of a blues player. So I thought it was interesting that they were a team that played together.

MR: How about Django?

JA: Passion. Fire. Brilliance. Absolutely just brilliant. There is no other word for it. I mean just how anybody could play that way. Again I mean even when I went to school there was this criticism that Django is not really a jazz player. He had so much of the gypsy fire and the certain kind of scaler thing that he would do and just the way he would play, he didn't sound like Charlie Christian. But to me it was still jazz. And I think that was one of the early experiences of hearing someone play who wasn't coming from the American jazz tradition but who was improvising this incredible stuff and playing standard songs that everybody played all around the world. But he had his own way of playing them. So he was unique. I mean passionate, fiery, brilliant, unique. And he did it all with just two fingers or something. It's pretty amazing.

MR: What about Jimi Hendrix?

JA: I consider Hendrix was like, he was the one rock & roll guitarist that I really listened to. I mean I didn't really listen to a lot of the other guys. I mean I heard them, I liked some things, but when I heard him it was like listening to a jazz musician but playing a different kind of music. He played so fluid and liquid and just soulful and he was so creative that he could have been playing anything. It could have been any instrument. The vocabulary was not jazz like I know jazz, but it felt really improvised. It felt loose too. It felt like it really had a loose kind of jazz quality. I just think he was just, he was the one I mean I kind of got when I heard that, when I heard an album called "Axis Bold as Love" that's when I went and bought a fuzz tone and a wah-wah pedal. And I said I really like this stuff. I want to, I don't know if I want to play like that but I mean I wanted to try to do some of that you know. And that was I think he had that impact on a lot of jazz musicians and not all the rock musicians did. You know I mean but Hendrix I think universally probably had a strong impact not only on guitar players but on a lot of people that grew up in my period, horn players, everybody, it was like, they'd hear it on a record and they'd know immediately it's Jimi Hendrix. The other guys I couldn't tell particularly. Later in years I wound up really liking Eric Clapton, but I didn't really care for Cream all that much. I mean I thought it was very interesting but it was kind of like a wall of notes that never really — it had a lot of energy to it and excitement but I didn't

really get the melody to it. It didn't seem very melodic. And I thought Hendrix was very melodic.

MR: Did you ever see him?

JA: No I never did. I'm surprised I never did because I saw so many great jazz musicians and I was in that scene playing with fusion bands but I never got to see a lot of the great rock players. I played opposite Chicago once, I remember that, and that was really enjoyable and I heard some bands, that band Mountain one time with Leslie West, it was so loud my stomach was rumbling. I had to leave. It sounded good but I remember it was in the Village Gate and it was just like the music had me pinned against the wall.

MR: Have you ever had any trouble with playing the fusion type thing and volume and all that?

JA: Oh yeah. Yeah, I mean, well I used to play with Cobham and sometimes you'd come off a gig and your ears would be ringing. And the roadie would come over and say, "Congratulations, you've gone beyond the threshold of pain for the third concert in a row." And I'd say no wonder. And now I play, yeah, not I just won't play so loud. I mean there's only so loud I'll play because it hurts my ears. There are certain frequencies that hurt my ears. I guess high frequencies really just go right through them. I remember a concert with Al DiMeola and Jan Hammer that I went to in San Francisco and I don't even think they were playing probably as loud on the stage as it was pumped out into the PA. And people were sitting there with their fingers in their ears listening to the concert. And some of them were just kind of like yeah man, grooving. And it was I was like I felt like someone had taken daggers and had jabbed them through my eyes, it was just like so painful I mean I just kind of I didn't want to have anyone see me I was kind of like really got down real low and crept out of the theater, just went away and said I can't listen to this. And maybe not at the fault of the musicians, you know it was just so loud. And I decided I never want to play music that loud, ever. It just has no place for me, I don't get it. And I have played it that loud.

MR: What about Weather Report? Do you have any thoughts on them?

JA: Well of all the groups I guess of those groups, the most colorful, the most musical, the most interesting. For a short period or a period, especially when I started playing the guitar synthesizer I kind always looked to Zawinul as kind of a role model. And since I was playing with Peter Erskine who had played with Weather Report, you know he would always give me some insight into how Joe would do something or how he thought about things. And it's interesting. He's a very creative man. He's one of the only people I can listen to play the synthesizers because he just uses them to create all this wonderful color and atmosphere and of course him and Wayne Shorter. It was a fabulous band. I mean I think there were two bands from that period that kind of stick out and I always say

it would be Weather Report and the Mahavishnu Orchestra that had completely different approaches to playing that kind of music, and of course Miles' bands. But I thought most of the other stuff that I would hear, including the stuff that I was involved in, not that it was bad, I mean some of the stuff I played with Billy Cobham's band was tremendous fun and I think some of it was quite good, but I think a lot of the music out there was just, after a while I think it was just people were just trying to make money. But yet I always felt with Mahavishnu it just was totally inspired kind of music and with Weather Report it was just these guys were just were so cool about putting things together, they just really did it. And when you tried to imitate it it never worked. I mean I always tried to imitate that stuff when I was younger and it just never quite worked, I don't know.

MR: One more little quote I was curious about here, you weren't talking about yourself I don't think, but you've noticed a syndrome that some people have where they feel guilty about being a great musician? Do you remember saying that?

JA: I don't know about being a — I think, well I think that gets into a — that could open up another whole can of worms. It gets very psychological. I mean I think when people aren't, I think if you don't feel, if you have trouble dealing with the fact that maybe you play well, it could be tied to a whole bunch of issues. And I don't know if it's a syndrome. I don't know if I really, well I've known a lot of players over the years, you know the kind of player that you know they'll finish something and it'll sound really good and I won't name any names but there are friends of mine and I'll go, "Oh that sounded really great," and they go, "oh man, I just can't, I can't get it together." I think maybe I was talking about that, the players that won't allow themselves to accept anything good about themselves you know, then there's the reverse of course, the people that are constantly you know, just like kissing everything they do. And I think there's just like, I think neither thing makes sense. I mean I think if you fall in love with everything you do and you don't have any editing, you don't have any criticism of your own playing, I think you're in trouble. But I think the reverse is also true, I mean if you walk around like beating yourself up because you don't think you can play, and yet, and that actually is the more dangerous of the two in a way because it stops the process. You're never really happy with what you do. I think I was talking more about that in that, but that's tied to like the whole issues of how people feel about maybe themselves and what their life was like when they were young, so then you get into stuff that actually comes up in a therapist's office which is very interesting but maybe not for the archives.

MR: Right. I can't help you.

JA: And I don't want to go there.

MR: There must be an awful lot of juggling in your career and of the guys who play with you.

JA: Yeah.

MR: Does that ever — do you ever juggle yourself into a corner with your commitments?

JA: It's happened, yeah. I try not to let it happen. I mean I'm usually pretty on top of it but I know there's been some occasions where I did get a phone call and they said, "Well don't you remember you said the last three weeks of October you would put aside?" And I say, "I did?" And I go back into my date book and I look in my little computer and I look through the little saved e-mails and all this stuff, this is technology, and I'm looking going gee I can't find anything are you sure? Well I remember the conversation. And so those things happen. They don't happen that often. But they do happen. I think they happen with a lot of musicians. You just might forget something. You just forget it. But a lot of the juggling also comes in just trying to get things arranged and trying to make sure all the musicians you're playing with, if it's your project, to make sure that everyone knows when it's happening and right now I'm trying to organize three separate things, which is two tours for next year and hopefully a recording for this year. And I think I finally have the tours period settled. But I was back and forth with e-mails and phones. And I remember speaking with Manfred Eicher on the phone about this recording project and he got very angry with me one time and he said, "I have to deal with hundred piece orchestras and you are talking about a jazz quartet." And I said, "Yeah okay Manfred." And I hung up the phone and then I'm speaking with Mark Feldman, the violinist, and saying, "I just had this conversation with Manfred." And he said, "Oh yeah," he said, "but most orchestras, they all have Fridays free, they work together, they're a band, they have—" you know. So it's actually harder to deal with a smaller group because you've got maybe three or four people, five people in a band, and they've all got different things going on all the time. Their own bands, projects with this one. Right now I'm trying to do some stuff with Joey Baron who played on my last record. I mean he's off playing with John Zorn and Frisell or whoever, and he's got all these like projects going on and I just want to do two things with him. And we finally found the periods to do them. And Mark Johnson the bass player. And Mark is like tremendously busy. And Mark Feldman on violin. So just trying to get four of us together to commit to like two periods of time was really hard but we finally got it. But there's a lot of that juggling probably going on more than any other kind of juggling. The stuff you're talking about, yeah, I just try to keep track of it and I try to write it all down.

MR: Right. For our guitar viewers, what's your instrument of choice these days?

JA: The actual instrument I'm playing?

MR: Yeah.

JA: Well I brought to the concert tonight I brought two instruments. It's funny because I was just listening to a couple of recordings coming up and for a long, for many years I played an Ibenez style Les Paul, then I switched to a Roger Sedowski telecaster style instrument,

which is on a lot of those recordings, which is a wonderful instrument. And then I switched more recently to a guitar made by a company called Brian Moore. It's called Brian Moore Custom Guitars. It's not custom made for me, but it's like a Les Paul with a switch for the guitar guys, a five way switch that you could move it and split the pick-ups and make it sound like single coil pick-ups if you want. It's got a beefy, fat sound. It's got a nice bridge pick-up and also under the bridge it has a piezo pick-up, which is sort of a fake acoustic pick-up for those that don't know. It's like a little crystals. Actually I don't know how this one works but they're under each string. And if you listen with your eyes closed from a distance of like several thousand yards it almost sounds like it's an acoustic instrument. So I used that kind of blended in with the magnetic pick-ups, with the regular guitar pick-ups, and I find it's an interesting, it creates an interesting sound. It still sounds like the guitar but gives it a little bit of shine it doesn't have normally. And I also brought a handmade guitar by a wonderful maker in California named Jim Mapson, which is like a little, very thin bodied archtop with one, just a pick-up in the neck. And I'll probably play that on a couple of tunes because it is a pretty open guitar so in a certain situation it may feedback a little but it's a wonderful instrument. So those are the two I'm playing mostly right now. I have a roomful of guitars.

MR: Yeah. Most guitar players—

JA: We tend to collect. Yeah I don't know how it happens. I had an old Les Paul, I've got my Ibanez, I've got a wonderful old 175, a used 175 from the 50s, which I never bring on the road but it's probably the best guitar I have. I have two handmade guitars by a maker named Rick McCurdy in New York that are wonderful, a big archtop and then a small body guitar, also lovely. And I have played them, they've all been on the road, they've all been on a record date, I mean they've all had some use but you can't use them all the time, which is a shame, I wish I could just have about ten hands, I could just like go around and play them all at once every day, just to keep everybody happy out there. Sometimes I think I should do that, just open up the case and say okay, now I'm going to play you for five minutes, and then at least we've communicated today.

MR: Good karma.

JA: Good karma. Well I think it's important. If an instrument sits too long it can die. I had a beautiful old guitar kind of die on me years ago, an acoustic instrument. And it'll happen.

MR: Anybody, just to wrap up, that you haven't played with that you wish you could?

JA: Well I've always said I mean it's probably because of my connection to Jim Hall and what he did with Sonny Rollins, I've gotten a chance to play with Jim, although I'd like to play with him a little more I mean maybe just one on one, that would be great. We've done some on concerts but it's never been real just sitting down in a room and playing you know. That would be very cool, I'd like to do that. But I'd love to play with Sonny

Rollins. And one drummer that, I've played with a lot of the great drummers, DeJohnette, I've played with Roy Haynes a few times and I've played with you know Billy Hart and just Peter Erskine, Adam Nussbaum, just a whole slew of great drummers, but I haven't played with Elvin Jones. And I just think that's got to be great. I mean how can that not be great? I mean it's impossible, that would be impossible not to feel great playing with him, I mean that's just — he's sort of like the epitome somehow of a certain kind of drumming and a certain kind of feel that I think I would just fall in play with very easily which is why I like to play with Nussbaum a lot because Nussbaum is kind of like comes from that basis you now, it's a very wide open just natural feel that just feels like yeah this is the way this music is meant to be played. So those two I would say, three including Jim. Of the sort of people you would know, you know, that's who I'd want to play with.

MR: [off camera comment] Anything you'd like me to — well — we'll leave that a mystery.

MR: I wish you the best in your future projects and juggling all the things. You know when I look at your resumes and so forth that people send out, it's quite amazing how much recording you've done and how many people you've played with and people that have played with you.

JA: Yeah there's a lot. One day I sat down I was traveling with Peter Erskine on a bus, this is a good seven, eight, maybe more, years ago. And we were both very bored and we were tired and he said, "Why don't you write down," he said, "everything you've ever recorded on" he said, "and you can leave nothing out." I mean even the worst possible like thing that you don't want anyone to know about, you have to include it. And we just kind of wrote down as many things as we could think. And I think at that time I was up to about like 80 or 90, and he was up to already recording, and he's younger than me, and he did about 150 projects. Can you imagine what a guy like Ron Carter and these people are probably like a couple of thousand albums you know.

MR: Can you remember the worst thing you ever did? Would you like to?

JA: You know I don't know if I can remember. Well I do remember one, and I could, yeah I do remember what I consider probably to be actually one of the worst projects I ever did, maybe the worst, and there were some great people on it, but, and I won't tell you the name of the person whose record it was because I've never heard from him since. I think he just, I think this was his one chance at trying to make a record. I don't know if he was a tax write-off or if somebody just really liked him and just wanted to give him a chance but he was a piano player and he really couldn't, he just couldn't play. But he had gotten this band together, actually on the record was myself, Jack DeJohnette, Stanley Clarke, Freddie Hubbard, and a lot of people, and more. You know I mean and that might have to go down, I can't remember, I do remember the name of the record, I remember the guy's name and it wouldn't be worth saying it but that was pretty bad. And I think I've actually

had a couple of people I've spoken to and said oh yeah, I heard that record, man what a terrible, what a rotten record that is, why did you do that? I only had one answer. I did it for money. Somebody offered me extremely good money to fly me out and do this project and I figured well all these great musicians, it's got to be good. And it wasn't, and in a situation like that it wasn't just that he didn't sound good, nobody really sounded good. Everything just kind of came down to this base level of just — I mean I sounded terrible, and it's hard to know when you're going to, how things are going to sound when you record or even when you play a gig but if you're going into a situation with people you don't really know anything about, it could get weird. I'm doing a recording actually on Sunday in Montreal with some Canadian musicians and Dave Liebman's playing on it. And I do know one of the musicians I know is playing, the other one I don't know that well, the drummer I don't know at all. But I know Dave and I know I got a sense this is probably going to be probably a pretty good one. I mean it will be good, I just hope that I play good on it. Because when you're recording you've got the whole recording thing, you know, can I hear myself properly, you know your recording is not a natural, it's not like playing in a club or a concert hall. Sometimes you can't hear what you're doing as well or you can't hear the piano or the horn player or the drummer, you're just not hearing properly. And a lot of times the recordings are made and people will say to me gee that was kind of a strange recording. I'll say look, I couldn't hear anything I played on that record. I remember doing one record where literally I think I played like by Braille. I mean I couldn't, I just couldn't hear the rhythm section. My sound sounded like it was coming from underneath blankets and the drummer sounded really far away, and that was just the best it could get in the headphones and it was a small studio and I just was dreadful. It doesn't sound so bad on the record but I remember, recording is a strange one. It can be really satisfying and it can also be very, very devastating if it's not good because then you hear the playback and it's like looking into a mirror you know. It's like seeing all the stuff you don't like, oh God, there's a wrinkle or why is that there. You see all the good stuff, but you also see a lot of the bad stuff about your playing.

MR: Well I hope those are few and far between for you.

JA: They're getting fewer and farther between as I get older, yeah.

MR: All right. Well thanks for your time today.

JA: My pleasure.

MR: I look forward to hearing you tonight.

JA: Okay, Monk. Nice to meet you.